

NEW CHIEF, OLD JOB
Congress candidate CM Charanjit Channi in Chamkaur Sahib

THOUGH INITIALLY ADJUDGED AN INNOCUOUS STOPGAP CM, CHANNI PROVED WILIER THAN HIS DETRACTORS, SIDHU, IN PARTICULAR

Sidhu (Jat Sikh) and Sunil Jakhar (Hindu). But Sidhu continued to taunt Channi's leadership with statements like, "People at the top want a weak chief minister who can dance to their tunes—*tha tha thaiyya*. Do you want such a CM?" At this point, Channi called for clarity. What helped him was AAP declaring Mann as its chief ministerial candidate. While driving to a rally recently, with Rahul, Sidhu and AICC general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal all in the same car, Channi popped the question. He said a clear choice would be good either way, and that he was willing to make way for anyone the party chose. Sidhu fell into the trap and offered to do the same, believing he was the more popular of the two. Rahul then called for an internal poll—after getting both leaders to commit to accept the decision. As it turned out, Channi won that round, leaving Sidhu in a stunned spell of silence, rare for him. But he had already ensured, with his untrammelled airing of views, that Channi had lost some of his sheen.

Armed with a clear mandate, that's what he's trying to recover. On a trip to his constituency Chamkaur Sahib, about an hour's drive from Chandigarh, Channi points to a water tank and newly-paved road at a village, to make the point that in the 111 days he was in power, he had brought speedy development across the state. "While AAP makes only promises, we have already delivered," he said. "If I am given a full five years by the people, I can achieve a lot." At one of the villages, people wave flags with the Congress hand symbol and the words, "*Sadda Channi, Sadda CM* (Our Channi, our CM)". Yet the Congress and Channi